AT LEAST 50 PER CENT OF ALL BJP MINISTERS IN FIVE NORTH-EASTERN STATES DEFECTED FROM OTHER PARTIES

The BJP grew exponentially because many senior leaders from other parties joined it. They brought with them their own support bases and influence networks. Very much like a corporation looking to expand into new areas, the party focused on winning the market by looking at the competition and acquiring as much of the rival talent as possible. Of course, it had to be attractive enough to pull in those it wooed. Himanta Biswa Sarma—who became the key strategist and the national face of the BJP's Northeast drive as convener of the NEDA as well as Assam chief minister—is only the most famous example of this strategy. Sarma was considered the Congress's second most powerful leader in Assam before he fell out with then chief minister Tarun Gogoi over the party's succession plans. Gogoi had recently introduced his son Gaurav into politics. He switched to the BJP, joining the party in August 2015.[69] Sarma had started his political career decades earlier with the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), which emerged out of the Assam movement of the 1980s. In the 2019 general election, he was the only BJP leader, apart from Narendra Modi and Amit Shah, who campaigned in every north-eastern state.

Sarma is certainly the best known among those who defected to the BJP before it came to power, but he was not the only one. In Assam, the top rungs of the BJP government formed in 2016 were full of former AGP and Congress stalwarts. Former chief minister Sarbananda Sonowal—a tribal leader from the Sonowal Kachari community, who was appointed minister of ports, shipping and waterways in the Central government in 2021—won his first election as an AGP MLA from Moran in 2011 before joining the BJP. Assam Assembly Speaker Hitendra Nath Goswami served three terms as an AGP legislator before joining the BJP in 2014. The state's parliamentary affairs minister, Chandra Mohan Patowary, served as president of the AGP in the 2008–2011 period and was leader of the Opposition in the state assembly between 2006 and 2011 before he joined the BJP.[70] Similarly, the party's ministerial list in Assam included a former State Congress Youth president (Pijush